Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

Topic 4.5 Guided Notes: Social-Cognitive and Trait Theories of Personality

Unit 4: Social Psychology and Personality | AP Psychology

Directions: Read through the topic overview page below and fill in each blank as you go. Use the tables and activities to check your understanding, then head to the quiz link at the end to test yourself.

Source page: appsychreviewhub.com/overviews/topic4.5

Word Bank

Agreeableness	*Extraversion*	*Reciprocal Determinism*
Self-Esteem	*Self-Concept*	*Neuroticism*
Openness to Experience	*Factor Analysis*	*Self-Efficacy*
Big Five Theory of Personality	*Conscientiousness*	

1. The Social-Cognitive Theory of Personality

Proposed largely by Albert Bandura, the social-cognitive perspective emphasizes the interaction between our traits and our situations. According to social-cognitive theory, _____ shapes personality. This is the interacting influence of three factors: your internal thoughts/cognition, your environment, and your behaviors.

This interplay heavily explores your _____, which is how you view yourself and your relation to others. Two distinct internal components contribute to forming it:

- _____: One's feelings of high or low self-worth. It is the overall evaluation you have of yourself.
- _____: One's sense of competence and effectiveness on a specific task. (e.g., If you believe you can successfully complete a difficult math problem, you have a high degree of this in that specific area.)

Apply It: Which Self-Concept Idea?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	Asked to finish the sentence “I am…” ten different ways, a student lists his roles, hobbies, and personality traits.	
2	A girl feels that she is a worthwhile person who deserves good things, and she is generally happy with who she is.	
3	A new cook is certain she can bake a perfect soufflé on her first try, though she doubts she could ever repair a car engine.	
4	A shy student joins the debate club (environment), grows more confident (thoughts), and starts speaking up in class (behavior), which leads classmates to include her more often.	

2. Trait Theories of Personality

Instead of trying to explain why people have certain personalities, trait theorists focus on describing what those personalities actually look like. Trait theories of personality conclude that personality involves a set of enduring characteristics that lead to typical responses to stimuli. These traits are relatively stable over time and across different situations.

The Big Five Theory

Today, the most widely accepted trait model is the _____. It proposes that human personality is made up of five core traits along a spectrum. You can easily remember them using the acronym OCEAN (or CANOE):

- O — _____: How willing you are to try new things and think outside the box. A high score means imaginative, independent, and loves variety; a low score means practical, conforming, and prefers routine.
- C — _____: Your level of organization, work ethic, and dependability. A high score means organized, careful, and highly disciplined; a low score means disorganized, careless, and impulsive.
- E — _____: Where you draw your energy from and how you engage with the outside world. A high score means sociable, fun-loving, and energetic; a low score (introversion) means reserved, quiet, and reflective.
- A — _____: How you relate to others in terms of cooperation, empathy, and compassion. A high score means soft-hearted, trusting, and helpful; a low score means suspicious, critical, and uncooperative.
- N — _____: How you experience and handle negative emotions. A high score means low emotional stability: anxious, insecure, and easily stressed. A low score means high stability: calm, secure, and self-satisfied.

💡 *Note: The AP framework often identifies this last trait as Emotional Stability, which is just its inverse.*

Assessing Traits: Factor Analysis

How do psychologists know that these five distinct traits exist? These traits are measured by specialized personality inventories that use _____ to organize item responses. This is a complex statistical procedure that identifies clusters of related test items. For example, if people who say they "like parties" also consistently say they "like talking to strangers," the procedure groups those responses together under a single broader social trait.

Apply It: Which Big Five Trait?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	A man picks up an unfamiliar instrument every few months, tries a new hobby each season, and loves debating wild, unconventional ideas.	
2	A man lays out his clothes the night before, updates his budget every day, and always arrives early to work.	
3	A woman who loves being the center of attention chats with everyone in her office and throws a party nearly every weekend.	
4	A coworker who always volunteers to help, trusts people easily, and tries to calm down arguments.	

#	Scenario	Concept
5	Before every flight, a woman is overwhelmed with dread, imagines every way it could go wrong, and can't calm down for hours afterward.	
6	A worker who rarely meets deadlines, keeps a cluttered desk, and often forgets meetings (a very low score).	
7	A manager who assumes his coworkers are out to cheat him, picks fights over small things, and refuses to compromise (a very low score).	

3. Don't Trip Up! (Common Misconceptions)

⚠️ Self-Concept vs. Self-Esteem vs. Self-Efficacy: These three terms sound incredibly similar but have distinct meanings on the AP Exam.

- _____ is the broad answer to the question “Who am I?” (e.g., “I am an athlete, a good friend, and a student”).
- _____ is how much you value that concept (e.g., “I am happy with who I am”).
- _____ is your belief in your ability to do a specific thing (e.g., “I believe I can sink this three-point shot”).

4. Quick Check: Review Questions

Circle the best answer for each question below.

1. When asked to describe who she is, a woman says, "I am a mother, a nurse, a marathon runner, and someone who loves painting." This broad, organized collection of beliefs and perceptions a person holds about their own identity and traits is called:

A. Self-Efficacy
B. Self-Concept
C. Self-Actualizing Tendency
D. Self-Esteem

2. Standing at the free-throw line during a critical moment in a basketball game, a player feels completely confident that she has the specific skill and ability needed to successfully make this particular shot. This belief in one's competence to accomplish a specific task is called:

A. Unconditional Positive Regard
B. Self-Concept
C. Self-Esteem
D. Self-Efficacy

3. A woman spontaneously books a solo trip to a country she has never visited, eagerly tries unfamiliar and exotic foods at every restaurant, and spends her weekends exploring abstract art museums that challenge her thinking. According to the Big Five, she would likely score very high on which trait?

- **A.** Agreeableness
- **B.** Openness to Experience
- **C.** Neuroticism
- **D.** Conscientiousness

4. A student frequently misplaces his homework assignments, waits until the very last night before an exam to begin studying, and tends to make major life decisions on a complete whim without much forethought. According to the Big Five, he would likely score very low on which trait?

- **A.** Extraversion
- **B.** Agreeableness
- **C.** Openness to Experience
- **D.** Conscientiousness

5. A man tends to panic and spiral into significant anxiety over even minor, unexpected changes to his daily plans, and he dwells heavily and repeatedly on his past mistakes long after they have occurred. According to the Big Five, he would likely score very high on which trait?

- **A.** Emotional Stability
- **B.** Agreeableness
- **C.** Neuroticism
- **D.** Conscientiousness

6. Researchers analyzing responses to a new personality inventory notice that people who report they "like going to parties" also consistently report that they "enjoy meeting new people" and "feel energized in social settings." This complex statistical procedure, which groups these related items together under one broader trait, is called:

- **A.** Reciprocal Determinism
- **B.** Factor Analysis
- **C.** Projective Testing
- **D.** Self-Efficacy

✅ Check Your Progress

Done with your notes? Head over to the Quiz to test what you've learned:
https://appsychreviewhub.com/quiz

Source content adapted from Psych Review Hub — Topic 4.5: Social-Cognitive and Trait Theories of Personality (appsychreviewhub.com)